



PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR

Gurjars feel doubly threatened after the delimitation process which has reduced their political clout in the Lok Sabha as well as the state Assembly.

will ensure them seats not only in panchayat and local bodies but also in the state Assembly and the Lok Sabha. The only Lok Sabha seat where Gurjars are a majority is Dausa where delimitation has diluted their strength considerably. It is now an ST reserved seat, which has forced sitting MP Sachin Pilot to look for an alternative seat. Half a dozen other Assembly seats currently with Gurjar MLAs will also be affected by delimitation and further reduce their political clout.

Why did the state machinery bungle despite armed with last year's experience? The bureaucracy and police are notorious for treating certain castes and communities with contempt and Raje was made to believe that the Gurjar agitation would have no impact. This, despite the fact that throughout the year, they had kept up their agitation, albeit largely peaceful. Unfortunately, that gave officials and ministers a false sense of security. Moreover, the Government machinery was diverted in the aftermath of the Jaipur blasts.

Apart from this, the Government also failed to anticipate the level of violence. Until last year, Gurjars were not known to indulge in mob violence but given social and geographic conditions—the infamous Chambal ravines run through the area and many live in such pathetic conditions that anti-social elements are bound to emerge—it was a mistake on the part of authorities to not have warned the police against direct confrontation. The result was avoidable clashes, for example, in Sikandra in Dausa district where the Gurjars attacked police and the Central Reserve Police Force and snatched a rifle. A furious force demanded orders for firing which resulted in deaths mounting

BODYBAGS: Gurjars mourn their dead; Raje (left) has a tough choice to make

further. The violence quickly spread outside the state as major highways and rail lines were blocked, affecting transport of goods as well as seriously affecting tourism. The state is losing Rs 50 crore every day because of the blockade.

For Raje, the timing could not have been worse. She will have to pay a heavy price in the coming Assembly elections unless she does some serious damage control. She is between the devil and the deep sea. The general opinion in Rajasthan has turned against the Gurjars who are now looked upon as a violent community. In Sikandra, they poured boiling oil on a bystander and have been openly displaying arms. Moreover, notorious dacoits like Jagan Gujjar have joined the agitation. Equally, the public is angry with Raje for her failure in maintaining law and order. They also question why the Meenas should protest Gurjar demands when both are perceived to be equally undeserving of ST status.

Despite Raje's feeble attempts to pass the buck, the Centre is unlikely to get involved in the messy issue unless Raje specifically recommends it, a move that is fraught with serious political repercussions. Dealing with Bainsla remains her best bet but this time he is not likely to give in so easily. The more serious problem is that mass agitations involving a community have a history of getting out of hand and becoming a long-term national law and order problem. With the agitation reaching the outskirts of the national capital, the symbolism is ominous.